

# **Korean Philosophy from a Comparative and Intercultural Perspective**

11th Annual Conference of the North American Korean Philosophy Association (NAKPA)

## **Book of Abstracts**

*5–6 October 2026 · University of Hildesheim, Main Campus (Universitätsplatz 1)*

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## Plenary Sessions & Keynote

### Opening & Greeting

*Monday, 5 October · 09:00–09:30 · Musiksaal*

Halla Kim (Sogang University, NAKPA President) · Sool Park (University of Hildesheim, Local Organizer) · Rolf Elberfeld (University of Hildesheim)

### Keynote Address

*Monday, 5 October · 09:30–10:30 · Musiksaal · Chair: Halla Kim*

Marion Eggert (Ruhr-Universität Bochum)

### Plenary Panel 1 • Author-Meets-Critics — Jin Y. Park, *Marginality* (Columbia UP, 2025)

*Monday, 5 October · 10:45–12:15 · Musiksaal · Chair: Sool Park*

Critics: Anthony Curtis Adler (Yonsei University), Yoko Arisaka (University of Hildesheim), Youngsun Back (Sungkyunkwan University), George Tsai (University of Hawai'i) · Respondent: Jin Y. Park (American University)

### Joseon Political Philosophy

Slot 1 · 14:00–15:30 · Musiksaal (HC.K.1) · Chair: David Kim (University of San Francisco)

#### 1. Hyeon Sop Baek University of Hawai'i

##### *Freedom and Decoloniality in Jeong Do-jeon's Thought*

This paper aims to explore the underlying philosophy of Jeong Do-jeon's work *Bulssi Japbyeon* (Array of Critiques Against Buddhism), and to identify that his main intention consisted not necessarily in criticizing Buddhism but primarily in advocating for a theory of freedom, which ultimately provided further foundation for his political philosophy, and to suggest that it can provide resources to tackle problems stemming from Orientalism within contemporary society. While many view Jeong as a political figure and focus on his political theory, it is critical to examine his philosophical foundations. In particular, his work *Bulssi Japbyeon*, while taking the form of a criticism of Buddhism, provides a significant insight into his philosophy, directed not necessarily against Buddhism but rather toward an approach to a life of freedom and authenticity. According to Jeong, this consists in not letting any external factors, such as fear of death or a desire for life, serve as the guiding valuation scheme in one's life, but in being truthful to oneself regardless of the circumstances one is in, as he explains through his invocation of Mencius. I conclude the paper by contrasting this approach to life with the internalization of the Orientalist worldview within contemporary society.

#### 2. Juyong Kim University of Warwick

##### *Mencian Autonomy in the Social World: Reinterpretation of the Contemporary Neo-Confucian Reading of Mencius through Dasan*

This essay seeks to reinterpret Mou Zongsan and Lee Ming-huei's reading of Mencius as a theory of moral autonomy. Whilst in agreement with Mou and Lee in that the moral philosophy of Mencius, *avant la lettre*, centres around the Kantian conception of autonomy, I propose that we better elucidate the distinctiveness of Mencius's autonomy by highlighting its performative and social character. I contend that the Mencian moral agent is best characterised as (1) self-determination, (2) achieved through interpersonal actions and (3) motivated by natural moral senses. To this aim, in light of Dasan's Essential Meanings of Mencius (孟子要義), whose reading significantly diverges from Mou and Lee's approach, I argue for three interpretive claims: (1) *duan* (端) as beginning enables us to construe virtues as accomplishments of moral self-cultivation conducted by practical agents; (2) *ren* (仁) as interpersonality characterises moral values as incorporating down-to-earth social norms; (3) *xing* (性) as natural preference (嗜好) puts moral senses in interactive constitution with the active heart-mind (心) in moral agency. Reading Mencius in this line brings Mencius's autonomy considerably close to Hegel's model of autonomy, in which freedom finds its genuine realisation in unity with natural inclinations and social norms in ethical life (*Sittlichkeit*).

#### 3. Nikolett Roque-Kőrösi Károli Gáspár University

##### *Minbon and Political Responsibility in Silhak Thought*

The concept of *minbon* (민본, 民本) refers to the idea that political order can only be maintained when the ruler cares for the people and governs for their benefit. This principle occupies a central place in Confucian political thought and also played an important role in the founding of the Joseon dynasty. References to the people as the basis of political and social order already appear in classical texts such as the *Shijing* (詩經) and *Shujing* (書經). The idea was further emphasized in the thought of Mencius through *min gui jun qing* (民貴君輕), which highlights the importance of the people in the stability of the state. Consequently, throughout Chinese and Korean intellectual history, Confucian scholars frequently referred to and emphasized the principle of *minbon*. Nevertheless, a significant conceptual shift can be observed between earlier interpretations of *minbon* and the way it was understood by thinkers associated with the *Silhak* (실학, 實學) tradition. The motivation for this study partly arises from my previous research on Jeong Dojeon (정도전, 鄭道傳; 1342–1398), whose writings on governance stress that political and social stability lies on the

state of the people. Observing how similar ideas appear in later Silhak texts raises the question of how these thinkers reinterpreted minbon in the changing socio-political context of late Joseon. Drawing on Silhak texts associated with thinkers Yi Ik (이익, 李穡; 1681–1763), and Jeong Yakyong (정약용, 丁若鏞; 1762–1836), this paper examines concepts such as aemin (愛民, 애민; “loving the people”), wimin (爲民, 위민; “governing for the people”), and minsaeng (民生, 민생; “the people’s livelihood”). These concepts demonstrate how Silhak thinkers increasingly connected Confucian ethics with practical reforms aimed at improving social stability and the material well-being of the population. The paper explores how Silhak political thought used and reframed minbon as a principle of practical political responsibility, emphasizing that legitimate governance must actively secure the welfare and livelihood of the people.

## Dasan Jeong Yagyong

Slot 1 · 14:00–15:30 · HC.J.1.07 · Chair: Boram Jeong (University of Colorado Denver)

### 1. Sang Hyun Chung

#### *The Human Body (shin) in Tasan's Philosophy*

The Understanding of the Human Body (shin, 身) in Tasan's Philosophy – The Distinction of the Human Body from Substance (ch'e, 體) and the resonate relationship of Body and Mind Sang Hyun Chung Abstract(184 words) Tasan Chŏng Yagyong examined the human body and its relationship to the mind. In contrast to Neo-Confucianism, which dominated intellectual discourse in the Joseon dynasty, he proposed two significant points for understanding the human body. First, he emphasized a distinction between the human body and other substances (ch'e, 體), arguing that the human body does not belong to the same category of ch'e. Second, rather than accepting the primacy of the mind (sim, 心) or function (yong, 用) over the body, Tasan insisted on the equality of these two poles. Through these claims, Tasan questioned the Neo-Confucian cosmology that assumes all material entities share the same ch'e, instead emphasizing the unique characteristics of the human body. To clarify this differentiated understanding, I reconstruct Tasan's writings, particularly 「Simgyeongmilheom (心經密驗)」 and 「Jungyong gangui (中庸講義)」. Based on this reconstruction, I argue that Tasan develops his own anthropological framework grounded in the distinctive and resonant relationship between mind and body. Furthermore, he takes this understanding as the basis for formulating a normative discipline that emphasizes the enactment of moral values through practice, rather than merely their intellectual comprehension.

### 2. Insok Hwang Sungkyunkwan University

#### *The Moral Subject of 'Weighing': Dasan's Theory of Quan*

The Rise of the Moral Subject of 'Weighing': Dasan's Theory of Quan within the Hermeneutical Tradition of East Asian Confucianism The Rise of the Moral Subject of “Weighing”: Dasan's Theory of Quan(權) within the Hermeneutical Tradition of East Asian Confucianism During the 18–19th Century, East Asian Confucian literati initiated a series of intellectual projects aimed at deconstructing and reconstructing the traditional Neo-Confucian (Zhuxi) worldview. Within this intellectual-historical current, Dasan(茶山) Jeon Yak-yong(丁若鏞, 1762-1836) is widely recognized for re-illuminating human moral subjectivity and practical autonomy through his logic of “Weighing and balancing”(權衡, Gwonhyeong). Previous scholarship has primarily identified the theory of free will, derived from Western Learning (西學, Seohak) texts, as the influential factor. However, It has relatively escaped scholarly attention that Jeong Yak-yong's Theory of Gwonhyeong originated from a highly reinterpretation and a fundamental shift in perspective regarding Quan(權, moral weighing/discretion), an ethical concept found in ancient Confucian classics. Historically, Quan has functioned as a conceptual tool for deliberating on—or “weighing”—diverse and complex moral dilemmas. Nevertheless, the classical texts of the Analects and the Mencius exhibit a degree of exegetical ambiguity regarding the concept of Quan, thereby inviting diverse hermeneutical perspectives. Among these, the interpretation offered by Zhu Xi emerged as the most authoritative. Unlike Zhu xi, Dasan shifted the focus of Quan toward the persona performing that act of weighing: the moral subject. It is noteworthy, however, that the precursors to this interpretation can already be discerned in Ito Jinsai's conceptualization of Quan. Approaching Dasan's theory of Gwonhyeong through the lens of East Asian Confucian exchange via classical interpretation provides a hermeneutic basis for reading the Confucian classics not as a closed set of dogmatic messages, but as a medium containing open-ended problems and inquiries. Furthermore, it offers a pivotal opportunity to trace the theoretical trajectory of how

the "birth of the moral subject"—a central keyword in modern Western moral philosophy—was introduced and established within the East Asian Confucian world.

### 3. Eun-Young Kim Sungkyunkwan University

#### *Moral Inclination and the Guarantee of Moral Order: Jeong Yakyong in Comparative Dialogue with Hume and Kant*

This paper situates Jeong Yakyong (1762–1836) within a triangular comparison with David Hume (1711–1776) and Immanuel Kant (1724–1804) in order to reconsider the foundations of moral judgment and its metaphysical grounding. Jeong defines human nature not as a set of innate moral virtues but as a structure of preferences (Ho-o, 好惡), fundamental tendencies of liking and disliking. In this respect, his account parallels Hume's theory of moral approval and disapproval, according to which moral distinctions arise from affective responses rather than pure reason. Both thinkers locate the motivational basis of morality in human sentiment. Yet Jeong departs significantly from Hume by introducing Sangje (上帝), a transcendent moral authority who observes human conduct and administers reward and punishment. Moral order is thus not merely psychological but grounded in a normative cosmological framework. In this regard, Jeong stands closer to Kant, who, while grounding morality in rational autonomy rather than inclination, nevertheless postulates God and immortality as necessary conditions for the ultimate coherence of moral striving. Through this triangular analysis, the paper argues that Jeong articulates a distinctive model integrating moral inclination with metaphysical guarantee, thereby reconfiguring the nature–freedom relation from an intercultural perspective.

## Modern Korean Thinkers

Slot 1 • 14:00–15:30 • HC.J.2.09 • Chair: Song Chong Lee (Seoul National University)

### 1. Jae Won Edward Chung Rutgers University

#### *A Cosmotechanical Approach to Korean Vitalism: The Case of Kim Chiha*

As a concept, saengmyŏng (生命, life/vitalism) has served as a key site of emancipatory possibility in Korea's tumultuous journey through modernity, encompassing and exceeding spiritual, biological, ethical, and political dimensions during periods of major geopolitical and ecological crisis. Ch'öndogyo intellectual Yi Tonhwa syncretized Donghak cosmology with Bergson's élan vital and Herbert Spencer's evolutionary theory in Sinin ch'örhak (1931), a synthesis mediated through Japanese intellectual discourse (Yi Ch'öl-ho) and produced translingually through the friction of colonial translation (Lydia H. Liu). In the 1980s, poet and political dissident Kim Chiha developed his own vitalism by building on the Donghak concept of kaebyŏk (開闢, cosmic renewal) and the millenia-old concept of ki (氣) and proposing an ethics of mosim (reverence) and salim (enlivening) that contests the extractive and industrialist logic of capitalist modernity. Drawing from Yuk Hui's cosmotechneics—the idea that different civilizations produce distinct unifications of cosmic-moral order through technical practices—I argue that Korean vitalism is neither authentically indigenous nor derivatively Western. To address threats posed by artificial intelligence and ecological disaster, the cosmotechneics of a new vitalism can draw from vocabularies of reciprocity and co-existence without slipping into a naïve posthumanism that neglects the materialist forces that continue to shape our world (Paul Rekret).

### 2. Hye Young Kim École Normale Supérieure, Paris

#### *Shame and Ethical Self-Relation: Yun Dong-Ju in Dialogue with Agnes Heller*

This paper revisits the concept of shame through a dialogue between the Korean poet Yun Dong-Ju and the philosopher Agnes Heller, approaching shame not as a merely social or moralizing affect, but as an existential mode of self-relation. Yun's poetry, written under colonial conditions, is often interpreted in nationalist or historical terms. Against such readings, I argue that Yun's articulation of shame points to a deeper structure of conscience and responsibility that cannot be reduced to political failure or external judgment. Drawing on Agnes Heller's analysis of shame as an affect situated between self-exposure and moral agency, I show how shame functions as a site where the self confronts itself under both the gaze of others and its own ethical demand. Shame, on this account, is neither simply destructive nor something to be overcome, but an ambivalent condition of ethical self-understanding. By placing Yun Dong-Ju's poetry in conversation with Heller's moral philosophy, the paper develops an intercultural

perspective on shame as a lived affect that illuminates the formation of ethical subjectivity through vulnerability, restraint, and responsibility rather than heroic self-assertion.

### 3. Juman Kim Towson University

#### *'We Must, But Cannot': Ham Sok Hon on Revolution, Religion, and the Politics of Humanism*

Ham Sok Hon (1901–1989)—a Quaker, Korean translator of the Bhagavad Gita, and philosopher versed in Laozi and Mencius—remains one of the most original yet underappreciated voices in modern Asian political thought. His 1959 essay “We Must, But Cannot, Resort to Revolution” crystallizes the central paradox of his political philosophy: the existing political order demands radical transformation, yet no revolution premised on the seizure of power can deliver it without reproducing the very domination it seeks to overthrow. For Ham, the demand and impasse of revolution are not a counsel of despair but the point of departure for a deeper inquiry into the relationship between politics, religion, and the nature of humanity. This paper examines Ham’s political thought through a sustained comparison with the Jewish philosopher Martin Buber (1878–1965), arguing that the juxtaposition highlights both the significance and the limits of Ham’s position. Both thinkers draw on marginalized religious traditions—Ham on a syncretic convergence of Christianity, Daoism, and Confucian ethics and Buber on prophetic Hebrew covenant theology—as resources for a humanist political vision that transcends the binary of secular realism and religious fundamentalism. Yet where Buber develops a concrete political program through his philosophy of dialogical relation, Ham’s gesture toward a “new religion” as the resolution of the political impasse necessitates further substantiation. By situating Ham in this comparative frame, the paper sheds light on his relevance to contemporary debates about the limits of secular political rationality, the dangers of both state power and revolutionary violence, and the possibility of a renewed humanism that draws on religious traditions without collapsing into theocracy or fundamentalism.

## Mid-Joseon: Four-Seven Debate & Seongho

Slot 2 · 16:00–17:30 · Musiksaal (HC.K.1) · Chair: Jin Y. Park (American University)

### 1. Jeseong Bae / Youngsun Back Sungkyunkwan University

#### *When Moral Emotions Go Wrong: Fittingness and Moral Propriety in the Four-Seven Debate*

**When Moral Emotions Go Wrong: Fittingness and Moral Propriety in the Four-Seven Debate**  
Abstract: Is it morally appropriate to feel compassion for a criminal? And should the compassion of someone who feels for a suffering child but fails to act be considered morally proper? These questions reveal a fundamental ambiguity in the evaluation of moral emotions. In one sense, an emotion may be appropriate insofar as it fits its object; in another, it may be inappropriate because it fails to guide action in morally acceptable ways—an issue that has been central to the Korean Confucian tradition. This paper offers an analysis of the Toegye and Yulgok schools’ debate on improperly measured moral emotions (sadan bujungjeol 四端不中節). We argue that this debate reflects a deeper divergence in how emotions are situated within moral life. For the Toegye school, moral emotions function as sources of moral awareness. As such, they can misfire, requiring a distinction between the fittingness of an emotion and its moral propriety. By contrast, the Yulgok school understands emotions as expressions of an integrated moral-psychological structure, in which their correctness is determined by the overall harmony of the system, collapsing this distinction. By bringing this debate into dialogue with contemporary philosophical discussions on the appropriateness of emotions, the paper shows how Korean Confucianism offers a distinctive framework for understanding their normative status.

### 2. Jaeryung Lim Ewha Womans University

#### *Seongho Yi Ik's Theory of Perception (Jigak): A Comparative Study with Yulgok Yi I*

This study aims to clarify the characteristics of Seongho Yi Ik (星湖 李瀼, 1681–1763)’s theory of mind from the perspective of ‘perception (Jigak, 知覺)’ through a comparative analysis with Yulgok Yi I (栗谷 李珥, 1584–1536). While Western philosophy traditionally treats perception as an epistemological process of grasping external reality, Eastern philosophy situates it within a broader context. In the Confucian tradition, the object of perception is principle (li, 理). Consequently, perception is not merely a cognitive function but can be understood as a moral mechanism that contains moral principle. It addresses the fundamental ethical question: How does the mind achieve moral perception? The question of how to understand the various dimensions of perception was a central concern for Joseon Confucian scholars. Seongho, in particular, developed a unique position on this subject, even composing a

dedicated essay under the title of 'Perception.' While previous research on Seongho has primarily focused on the 'Four-Seven Thesis' regarding human emotions, this study seeks to provide a more comprehensive understanding of his philosophy by centering on perception. Furthermore, this analysis necessitates a comparison with Yulgok. Seongho explicitly declared himself a successor of Toegye Yi Hwang(退溪 李滉, 1501-1570) aiming to refute Yulgok's ideas. However, despite his stated intentions, scholars have often noted structural similarities between Seongho's and Yulgok's theories of mind. Given that contemporary research often identifies perception as the core of Yulgok's philosophy, comparing the two is essential to identifying the distinctiveness of Seongho's thought. By examining these nuances, this study clarifies how Seongho reconstructed his theory of mind within the intellectual landscape of Joseon.

### 3. Hajin Oh Ewha Womans University

#### *Gong in Seongho Yi Ik's Theory of Four Beginnings and Seven Emotions*

This study aims to clarify the meaning of gong(公) in Seongho Yi Ik's theory of the Four Beginnings and Seven Emotions. This paper aims to examine the distinctive characteristics of the concept of gong(公) introduced by Seongho Yi Ik in contrast to that found in other texts, and to confirm that he constructs a distinctive ethical framework through this concept of gong. Seongho Yi Ik engaged with the Four-Seven Debate in order to defend the position of Toegye Yi Hwang. In doing so, he was compelled to respond to the arguments of Gobong Gi Daeseung, Yulgok Yi I, and the Kiho School. To accomplish this, he distinguished the Four Beginnings from the Seven Emotions by employing the predicates gong(公) and sa(私). The introduction of the gong-and-sa framework by Yi Hyeonil, who preceded Seongho, as well as by Seongho himself, was undertaken in order to respond to the logic of the Kiho School, their theoretical rivals. Accordingly, this study will examine the theory of the Four Beginnings and Seven Emotions advanced by Yulgok Yi I, the most representative scholar of the Kiho School. In doing so, it will be confirmed that Yulgok Yi I focused not only on the metaphysical structure of the emotions but also on whether those emotional phenomena were morally good. This parallels the way in which Seongho focused not only on the metaphysical structure of the emotions but also on whether they were gong or sa. Moreover, it is necessary to examine what distinctive ethics Seongho's characterization of the emotions in terms of gong and sa produces. This will demonstrate what is particular about Seongho's moral theory of the emotions, notwithstanding its formal similarities to Yulgok's Four-Seven theory.

## Neo-Confucianism & Silhak

Slot 2 · 16:00–17:30 · H.C.J.1.07 · Chair: Yoko Arisaka (University of Hildesheim)

### 1. Bongrae Seok Alvernia University

#### *The Horak Debate and Intercultural AI Ethics*

Korean Neo-Confucianism on the Moral Nature of Humans, Animals, and Artificial Intelligence: The Horak Debate and Intercultural AI Ethics Bongrae SEOK Alvernia University Korean Neo-Confucianism on the Moral Nature of Humans, Animals, and Artificial Intelligence: The Horak Debate and Intercultural AI ethics Abstract The goal of artificial intelligence (AI) is to build machines that can perform cognitive functions at the level of human intelligence. As AI technology advances, particularly in the areas of agentic and autonomous AI, machines can collaborate with human users and make decisions without supervision. In its ultimate form of intelligence, can AI become an artificial moral agent that can make moral decisions? How would Korean Neo-Confucianism answer this question? This paper analyzes how Korean Neo-Confucian philosophers in the Joseon period discuss the moral nature of human beings (in/ren 人) and non-human things/entities (mul/wu 物 such as animals with limited cognitive and moral abilities) and how their theories of the moral mind are related to the philosophical debates on the moral ability of AI from an intercultural perspective. Specifically, this paper discusses the moral agency of AI by interpreting and analyzing the inmulseong dongyiron (人物性同異論) of the Horak Debate (湖洛論爭), one of the major philosophical debates of Korean Neo-Confucianism. First, the paper argues that the Neo-Confucian discussion of inmulseongron (人物性論 i.e., a comparative analysis of the nature of human beings and non-human things) is a common and popular philosophical discourse in the mid Joseon period. Many Korean Neo-Confucian philosophers compared and analyzed the moral nature of human beings and that of non-human things. Second, the inmulseong discussion focuses on the moral metaphysical distinction between human beings and non-human things. Korean Neo-Confucian philosophers, such as Han Wonjin and philosophers of the Ho group, argue that human beings and non-human animals have different moral natures. However, in a broader context of moral goodness, the common nature of human beings and non-human



things can be understood from the perspective of the ultimate order of the moral universe that includes living things such as human beings and animals as well as non-living things situations, events, and artifacts. Korean Neo-Confucian philosophers, such as Yi Gan and philosophers of the Rak group, argue that human beings and non-human things have the same moral nature. In this context, one can interpret the inmulseong discussion of the Horak Debate as a debate between two competing approaches (Han Wonjin's "differential" approach and Yi Gan's "common/universal" approach) to moral agency. Third, the paper discusses stimulating philosophical implications of the inmulseong discussion of the Horak Debate to AI ethics from an Asian and intercultural perspective.

## **2. Suk G. Choi** Towson University

### *Scholars of Silhak on Music*

As a step towards the construction of Korean aesthetics, this paper aims to introduce discourse on music developed by representative scholars of Silhak in the late Joseon period, focusing on Damheon Hong Daeyong (1731–1783), Dasan Jeong Yagyong (1762–1836) and Hyegang Choe Hangi (1803–1879). Although scholars of Silhak identify them as Confucians, they critically approach traditional Confucian/Neo-Confucian philosophical ideas such as i-gi, human nature, and human mind-heart, which dominated in the Joseon period. Similarly, they attempt to re-examine these major Confucian/Neo-Confucian ideas of music as a tool in controlling emotions and communities and in considering the question of the body as a significant factor of musical effect; they incorporate the idea of gi as a philosophical foundation to expose the relationship between emotion, the mind/body, and music. This presentation addresses Silhak scholars' discussion on music to understand how they critically inherited traditional ideas and developed their practical concerns through the construction of theory, analysis of musical sound, and in many cases their artistic activities.

## **3. Chan Lee** Korea University

### *Vice in Neo-Confucian Ethics: Qi, Constitutive Luck, and Moral Responsibility*

This paper examines the problem of vice in Neo-Confucian ethics by situating it within the tension between temperamental constitution (qi-based nature) and moral responsibility. Neo-Confucianism explains vice primarily as a distortion or imbalance of temperamental endowment, thereby raising a fundamental philosophical question: if moral dispositions are significantly shaped by given conditions, to what extent can agents be held responsible for their actions? This problem becomes particularly acute when interpreted through the lens of constitutive moral luck. Engaging critically with Thomas Nagel's notion of constitutive luck, the paper argues that Neo-Confucian accounts of temperament exhibit a structurally similar concern regarding the conditions that shape moral agency, yet diverge in their normative implications. Whereas Nagel's framework tends to undermine the grounds of responsibility by emphasizing the uncontrollable formation of character, Neo-Confucianism preserves moral responsibility by positing the irreducibility of original nature (li) as a normative principle that remains intact despite the turbidity of qi. Through a comparative analysis of Zhu Xi, Yi Hwang, and Yi I, the paper demonstrates that Neo-Confucian ethics develops distinct strategies for negotiating the self-dependent structure in which qi appears to transform qi. These strategies do not eliminate the tension between constitutive conditions and moral agency but reconfigure it as a productive space for ethical cultivation. In this respect, vice is not merely a moral failure but a phenomenon that reveals the constitutive conditions of human agency while still allowing for meaningful transformation and responsibility.

## **Korean Buddhism I**

Slot 2 · 16:00–17:30 · HC.J.2.09 · Chair: Halla Kim (Sogang University)

### **1. Edris Voet** University of Oxford

#### *The 'Brief Transcriptions of Efficacious Resonance,' 1485*

Edris Voet (Final Year DPhil candidate in Korean Buddhism, University of Oxford), on The Exoteric and Esoteric Philosophies of the 'Brief Transcriptions of Efficacious Resonance,' 1485 This paper explores the exoteric and esoteric philosophies espoused by the 'Brief Transcriptions of Efficacious Resonance,' an appendage to the Five Great Mantras, a work of Korean Buddhism published in 1485. The 'Brief Transcriptions of Efficacious Resonance' is a summary of the mythological origins and miraculous function of four of the five mantras contained in the Five Great Mantras, and draws upon intertextual sources for its content, such as the Śūraṅgama-sūtra, the Great Compassion Dhāraṇī and



other works of Sinitic Buddhism. I will analyse the work from two perspectives: 1. the exoteric, namely the social function of mantras in the time of Buddhist decline, Queen Insu's rationale for the publication and dissemination of the work and the terrestrial functions of the mantras, and, 2. the esoteric, being the cosmic and universal benefits of mantra-chanting including the attainment of higher states on the path to total enlightenment. This paper is presented within the framework of Korean esoteric Buddhism and, while providing a detailed textual and historical introduction to the source material, will offer an analysis of core philosophical ideas in premodern Korean Buddhism with reference to the language of chant contained in the work.

**2. Sumi Lee** Ewha Womans University

*Between and Beyond the Ultimate and the Phenomenal*

Ewha Womans University Abstract This paper examines the philosophical problem of the relationship between the ultimate and the phenomenal, a central concern in religious thought. While Western theology has struggled to reconcile this relationship—most notably through the problem of theodicy—Buddhist traditions approach it as an underlying truth. Scriptural sources such as the Prajñāpāramitā-sūtra assert the non-duality of nirvana and samsara, suggesting that the ultimate and the phenomenal are not distinct. This study investigates how Buddhist thought accounts for this apparent paradox without collapsing their ontological and epistemological distinctions. In order to address this issue, the paper explores the philosophical meaning of the middle way through a comparative analysis of East Asian Buddhist exegetes' interpretations of "buddha-nature." By examining their differing perspectives, it articulates various frameworks in which binary distinctions are maintained yet transcended. Through this inquiry, it aims to clarify how non-duality is philosophically grounded within Buddhist soteriology.

**3. Moonsuk Heo / Hye Yu Sunim** Hanmaum Seonwon

*Korean Buddhism: Hanmaum Seonwon's German Branch*

This study develops a comprehensive globalization model for Korean Buddhism by synthesizing Ram Adhar Mall's intercultural philosophy and Hans Küng's global ethic, utilizing Hanmaum Seonwon's German branch in Kaarst as a primary case study. Mall's analogous hermeneutics serves as the methodological core, promoting unity without uniformity by recognizing cultural overlaps and enabling a "situatedly unsituated" perspective that respects diversity while avoiding cultural isolation. Mall's insistence on abandoning absolute truth claims allows for dialogues that transcend regional constraints. In tandem, Hans Küng's global ethic provides the normative framework for interreligious peace, emphasizing the Golden Rule and commitments to non-violence and gender partnership. The German branch exemplifies this model through the localization of Seon Master Daehaeng's concepts of One Mind (Hanmaum) and Juigong (empty doer, True Self), which encourage practitioners to entrust daily experiences to their inner foundation. Success is attributed to lay-oriented practices, cultural media like seonbeopga (Dharma songs) that foster resonance across barriers, and proactive social engagement through events like the Frankfurt Book Fair. Ultimately, this model illustrates how Korean Buddhism can transcend boundaries, bridging spiritual wisdom with ethical responsibility to contribute to a peaceful global community.

## DAY 2 — Tuesday, 6 October 2026

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### Joseon Political Philosophy & Governance

Slot 3 · 09:00–10:30 · Musiksaal (HC.K.1) · Chair: Song Chong Lee (Seoul National University)

#### 1. Heewon Byun Ewha Womans University

##### *The Political-Philosophical Role of Shu*

Shu is a concept through which Confucius expressed his Way in a single phrase, and which Mencius presented as a method of practicing ren. Accordingly, it has traditionally been interpreted as a moral principle articulated by sages such as Confucius. In recent years, however, with the growing interest in the study of emotions, a number of studies have approached Shu from the perspective of emotion or attitude, comparing and contrasting it with empathy and tolerance. Meanwhile, as both a moral principle and a concept associated with empathy and tolerance, Shu lends itself well to application in political contexts. Then, what would a politics grounded in Shu look like when advanced by a king who cannot freely express personal experiences in the political sphere? Beginning from this question, this study seeks to reposition the concept of Shu within the framework of political philosophy and to examine the role it played in the Joseon dynasty. In particular, a keyword search for Shu in the Seungjeongwon ilgi( 承政院日記, Diaries of the Royal Secretariat) reveals that the term appears more frequently during the early reigns of King Yeongjo and King Jeongjo than in those of other kings. By examining these notable indicators alongside the historical context of their reigns, this study aims to identify the background and circumstances in which Shu came to be used as a principle of governance. In other words, it examines whether Shu can be understood as empathy or a principle a kind of the Golden Rule, and reviews the concept within a political-philosophical framework through its application in the political context of the late Joseon dynasty.

#### 2. Ji-hyun Ahn Sungkyunkwan University

##### *The Canonization of the Simgyeong and Joseon Confucianism*

Traditionally, the study of Gyeonghak ( 經學, Confucian Classics and their exegesis) has been confined to the canonical framework of Chinese texts, ranging from the Five Classics ( 五經) to the Thirteen Classics ( 十三經). This paper challenges that boundary by arguing that Joseon Gyeonghak cannot be fully understood within this inherited canon alone.

It advances the central claim that the Simgyeong ( 心經, Classic of the Mind) by Zhen Dexiu ( 陳德秀, 1178–1235)—more precisely, the Simgyeong buju ( 心經附註, Supplemented Classic of the Mind) compiled by Zheng Minzheng ( 程敏政, 1445–1499)—was treated in Joseon as a quasi-canonical text comparable in status to the Four Books ( 四書).

While the Simgyeong remained peripheral within the Chinese Confucian tradition, it occupied a central place in Joseon's intellectual and political culture. It was adopted as a subject of Gyeongyeon ( 經筵, Royal Lectures) in the sixteenth century, officially published by the state, designated as a core text at the Seonggyungwan ( 成均館, National Academy), and generated more than thirty commentaries between the fifteenth and nineteenth centuries.

The canonization of the Simgyeong in Joseon thus represents a distinctive feature of Korean Gyeonghak and provides strong grounds for expanding the scope of Confucian canonical studies beyond the Thirteen Classics. More broadly, this study offers a comparative perspective on how canonical boundaries were reconfigured in East Asian intellectual history. At the same time, it contributes to ongoing efforts to reposition Korean philosophy within global philosophical discourse by foregrounding its distinctive focus on the cultivation of the mind.

#### 3. Hyangjun Lee Chonnam National University

##### *Joseon from the Perspective of Neo-Confucian Narrative*

Lee Hyang-jun (Center for Philosophical Research and Education, Chonnam National University, Republic of Korea) Abstract On December 3, 2024, South Korean society witnessed the return of a ghost: a sitting president's declaration of "emergency martial law," a term that most Koreans had consigned to the political unconscious of the twentieth

century. Though quickly nullified by the National Assembly, the event revived a classical Hamletian question about the nature of what had reappeared. This paper argues that what returned that night was not an aberration but a contemporary reflection of the sajok (士族) ruling order historically consolidated during the late Joseon dynasty, and that the five-hundred-year unfolding of Joseon Neo-Confucianism bears an ideological relation to this event. Building on earlier work from 2020, the paper offers a macroscopic reconstruction of Joseon history from 1392 onward through the lens of a "Neo-Confucian narrative"—understood as the singular phenomenon, within the broader history of Confucianism, of the fusion and eventual dissolution of Neo-Confucian ideology and the state. By contrasting the Joseon case with the Han-dynasty pattern in which empire preceded ideology, and by tracing the emergence of the yangban class, the Confucianization of society, and the persistence of familism into modern Korea, the paper shows how contemporary Koreans live as an opaque compound of inherited residues and present conditions. The question, as always, is how.

## Heart/Mind, Desire and Diagrams

Slot 3 · 09:00–10:30 · HC.J.1.07 · Chair: Suk G. Choi (Towson University)

### 1. Borum Kim Anyang University

#### *Jeong Yak-yong's 'Chu-seo': The Circuit of Reflected Desire*

**Abstract:** This paper investigates the moral philosophy of Jeong Yak-yong (Dasan, 1762–1836) through the concept of 'Chu-seo' (推恕), redefining it not as a conventional internal moral law or a Golden Rule but as a "Relational Architecture of Morality" arising from innate expectations and desires. Contrasting with modern Western ethics that emphasize either the autonomous legislation of the subject (Kant) or the binary reciprocity of the Golden Rule, Dasan locates the source of morality in the 'Between-ness' (Relational Field) where concrete desires and aversions interact. Dasan identifies 'Yangji' (良知, Innate Knowing) not as an abstract law, but as a primordial "Moral Taste" (Gi-ho, 嗜好)—an innate 'liking' for virtue and 'disliking' for evil rooted in the human spiritual essence (Great Body/大體). 'Chu-seo' serves as the practical mechanism of this taste: it is the "Method of the Measuring Square" (絜矩之道) where the subject transitively reflects their own desire—what they wish for from a superior—and transforms it into a proactive moral action toward a subordinate in a reflected relationship. This study argues that Dasan offers a sophisticated, systemic ethics of responsibility where autonomy is found through the Reflective Internalization of social expectations.

- Keywords: Jeong Yak-yong (Dasan), Chu-seo, Relational Architecture, Moral Taste (Gi-ho), Yangji

### 2. Sangwho Shin Academy of Korean Studies

#### *The Heart-Mind in Yulgok Yi I's Philosophy*

**Abstract>** This chapter examines the metaphysical foundations of Yulgok Yi I's philosophy, focusing on his theories of principle (i), vital force (gi), the heart/mind, and self-cultivation. It challenges the prevailing view that contrasts Yulgok with Toegye and argues instead that his thought unfolds within a continuous development from Zhu Xi through Toegye to Yulgok. Yulgok presents a non-dualistic structure of i and gi, in which the two are inseparable yet distinct in their modes of operation. While principle is non-active, universal, and inherently good, vital force serves as the active medium through which it is realized. He identifies the heart/mind as belonging to vital force while distinguishing it from the constitutional endowment. As an "empty and luminous" aspect of vital force, the heart/mind retains its original clarity and serves as the ground of moral transformation. This account culminates in Yulgok's theory of self-cultivation, which he reformulates as a threefold structure integrating the unaroused and aroused states of the heart/mind. Through this framework, he shows that moral realization is not merely an ethical ideal but is grounded in the structure of reality itself.

### 3. Maria Long Linnaeus University

#### *From Taiji tu to Cheonmyeong do: Comparative Cosmology*

**Comparative Cosmology in Chinese and Korean Neo-Confucian Diagrams** Maria H. Long Linnaeus University, Sweden

Neo-Confucianism distinguished itself from the classical Confucian tradition through its systematic metaphysics and the development of a full cosmology expressed not only in texts but also through a visual tradition of diagrams. The earliest canonical Neo-Confucian diagram, Zhou Dunyi's (1017-1073) Taiji tu (Diagram of the Supreme Ultimate), provided the foundation for later cosmological thought, yet the diagrammatic tradition in China did not develop into a

continuous system. In Korea, however, Neo-Confucian scholars expanded Zhou's model into a rich and didactic oriented diagrammatic corpus that became central to the intellectual formation of the Joseon Neo-Confucian tradition. Among the most influential works are Gwon Geun's (1352-1409) Cheonin Simseong Bunseok Jido (Diagram for the Analysis of Heaven, Humanity, Mind, and Nature) Jeong Ji-un Chuman's (1509-1561) and Yi Hwang Toegye's (1501-1570) Cheonmyeong do (Diagram of the Mandate of Heaven), This paper compares the cosmological structures expressed in the Taiji tu, the Cheonin Simseong Bunseok Jido, and the Cheonmyeong do, highlighting how Korean Neo-Confucians transformed Zhou Dunyi's original framework into a distinctive and more elaborate visual cosmology.

## Korean Buddhism II & Comparative Ethics

Slot 3 · 09:00–10:30 · HC.J.2.09 · Chair: Halla Kim (Sogang University)

### 1. Thapakorn Kamnerdsiri Thammasat University

#### *Won Buddhism, Ethics and the Others*

| Korean Studies Program , Department of Asian Studies, Faculty of Liberal Arts , Thammasat University Thailand.  
 ..... Others' Parents: Won Buddhism, Ethics and the Others. One of the central ethical principles of Won Buddhism is the concept of the Fourfold Grace it is particularly noteworthy that one of these four forms of grace in Won Buddhism is the grace of parents, However, the meaning and the responsibility to care of "parents" in this doctrinal context is extended beyond one's own parents to include the "parents of others." From the author's perspective, the expansion of the meaning of "parents" and the extension of filial gratitude toward the parents of others constitute a significant social ethical issue for three main reasons First, it opens a space for the "parents of others" within a relational domain that has traditionally been reserved exclusively for family relationships. Second, it broadens the meaning of gratitude to parents or filial piety—an ethical sentiment traditionally reserved for those who gave birth to and nurtured "oneself toward those who have " given birth to and raised "others." Third, the effort to extend gratitude and care toward the parents of others implies a process of cultivating and refining the delicate, subtle, and often fragile moral emotions of human beings for the development of a system of "social ethics"

### 2. Seolin Choi Ewha Womans University

#### *Non-Obstruction and Transcendental Freedom in Wonhyo and Kant*

Non-Obstruction and Transcendental Freedom in Wonhyo and Kant Abstract This paper argues that the difference between the concepts of freedom in Wonhyo(元曉) and Immanuel Kant cannot be adequately understood as a doctrinal divergence, but must be reconstructed in terms of the structure of the subject that grounds them. While existing studies engage their respective notions of freedom, they do not sufficiently clarify the subject that makes such concepts possible. This paper therefore shifts the problem of comparison itself by determining the subject of freedom as its condition. Wonhyo's 'One Mind(Il-sim,一心)' and Kant's 'Transcendental Apperception (transzendente Apperzeption)' each function as both the fundamental ground of their respective ontologies and the subject of freedom. Although both articulate a form of transcendence beyond the phenomenal domain, their internal structures diverge in a way that decisively shapes their concepts of freedom. For Wonhyo, freedom can be understood as 'non-obstruction(mu-ae,無礙)', the unobstructed functioning that transcends all conceptual distinctions, whereas for Kant it consists in 'transcendental freedom(transzendente Freiheit)', that is, the autonomy of reason as the self-legislation of transcendental apperception. This paper argues that this divergence is not contingent but structurally necessitated, and that it reconfigures how freedom itself must be understood across fundamentally different philosophical frameworks. (193 words)

### 3. WooHyun Jung Sogang University

#### *Immanent Transcendence in Tian, Kant, and Donghak*

This paper argues that four philosophical traditions—classical Confucian discourse on tian (天), Kant's account of pure practical reason, the Korean Donghak (東學) tradition from Suwon Choe Je-u through Haewol Choe Si-hyeong to Uiam Son Byeong-hi, and the twentieth-century Korean synthesis of Yu Young-mo (柳永模) and Ham Sok-hon (咸錫憲)—exhibit a structurally analogous response to the question of how the moral imperative can be at once internal to the human and unconditionally authoritative over her. I call this shared structure immanent transcendence and identify

four features common to all four cases: the moral source is internal to the human; it nonetheless exercises unconditional authority; it requires a specifically human mode of realization; and its realization is unending.

Taking Confucian tian as the primary axis of comparison, the paper reads Kant's Fact of Reason (Faktum der Vernunft) and his postulate of God as one critical-philosophical articulation of this structure, and the Korean traditions as developing the structure in registers that emphasize, respectively, experiential disclosure (Donghak), contemplative recovery (Yu Young-mo), and historical agency (Ham Sok-hon). The argument resists syncretism: the structural convergence is shown to be compatible with substantial divergences in epistemic stance, scope of moral consideration, and conception of moral telos. The traditions can illuminate one another, but cannot be flattened into a single tradition. The conclusion draws contemporary implications for ethics in an age that requires both protection against the political manipulation of religious experience and a moral vocabulary capable of extending regard beyond narrowly rational beings.

## The Realms of East Asian Literati Arts

Plenary Panel 2 · 10:45–12:15 · Musiksaal (HC.K.1) · Chair: David Kim (University of San Francisco)

**Panel presenters: Jiehua Cai · Cun-Yi Zhang · Elmar Oberfrank · Marc Nürnberger (all LMU Munich)**

*“Painted Memories? Constructed Truths? Poetic Thorns? Stoney Illusions?” — Intercultural Approaches to the Realms of East Asian Literati Arts*

The proposed panel unites four explorations into traditional East Asian literati arts guided by the question of the (material) status of the “realms” (經 境) ultimately produced by the scholars: What did the literati create in their artistic endeavors? What forces and tensions can be identified? Were they only driven by demons, desires, and personal ambitions? And what can be learned from engaging with these objects of art? Cai Jiehua follows Henri Bergson's insights into memory and reflects on the changes literati painting underwent in Joseon Korea. Zhang Cun-yi compares two exemplary “brush note” (筆記) works at the turn of the 16th/17th century, presenting the inherent struggles between the state and the individual from the perspective of knowledge construction. Inspired by soteriological readings of the “Journey to the West” (西遊記), Elmar Oberfrank elaborates on the warnings against the dangers of poetry as presented in the 64th chapter of the novel. Finally, Marc Nürnberger reads testimonies of Korean stone-lovers whose encounters with extraordinary stones challenge the ordinary conceptions of “materiality” and “reality,” closing the fourfold investigation into the “realms” that await the connoisseur of literati works.

### 1) Of Mind and Body: An Investigation into the Development of Korean Literati Painting — Jiehua Cai

Literati painting, often referred to as “poetry–calligraphy–painting” (詩書畫) in Korea, emerged primarily within the scholar-officials who engaged in painting, not as professional painters but as cultivated amateurs. They approached painting through the methods of calligraphy, emphasized conceptual expression of their mind, and thus created unique fields of experience for the viewer. When literati painting was transmitted to Korea, Korean literati relied primarily on visual impressions of Chinese paintings and painting manuals, instead of focusing on the actual landscapes of Korea. This presentation draws upon French philosophical theories to explore the relationship between memory, body and painting, especially in regard to the later developments of Korean literati painting, when painters successfully integrated embodied experiences of observed Korean landscapes into the framework of Chinese brushwork traditions. Put in Bergson's terms, this paper approaches literati painting as a transformation of both nature and the artist's inner state through the dynamic intersection of different memories, resulting in works that embody vivid subjectivity and poetic resonance at the same time.

### 2) Ways to True Knowledge: A Comparative Study on Late Ming and Joseon Korean Literati Brush Notes — Cun-Yi Zhang

Despite their sheer volume in traditional East Asian literature, the role of “brush notes” (筆記) in the pursuit of ideas and knowledge is still understudied. This paper argues that the conceptual reciprocity between the “brush” (筆) and the act of “noting/recording” (記) formed a seemingly marginal, yet provocative relationship between individual authors and state authority. This symbolic association made the art of writing an act inherently private, yet also the

foundation for any official document. The tensions between authorial motives, state ideology, fact and fiction, and the truth dangling between the two, make this genre a unique field for the study of the dynamics of individual and state pursuits of true knowledge. After a preliminary discussion of “brush” and “records” in the terms of traditional Chinese literary criticism, a comparison of Wang Shizhen's 王世貞 Collection of Marginal Words from the Yanshan Hall (弇山堂別集) and Yi Sugwang's 李睦光 Topical Discourses of Jibong (芝峰類說) shows how knowledge was possible for individual authors—despite their differences in negotiating personal intellectual concerns and state interests.

### 3) Encountering the Thorny Ridge: A Close Reading of the 64th Chapter of the “Journey to the West” — Elmar Oberfrank

Some readers of the “Journey to the West” (西遊記) saw beyond the entertaining value of the pilgrim's quest. Yu Manju 俞晚柱, for example, who also admired the novel, acknowledged the presence of inner alchemistic techniques, but preferred to treat the text as a “discussion of the heart” (論心) from a Buddhist point of view. The highly symbolic 64th chapter tells of the hidden dangers of the “Thorny Ridge” (荊棘嶺) where the pilgrim gets abducted and entangled in a poetic exchange with four learned tree spirits. However, this favorite literati pastime almost ends in the nightly seduction by an apricot goddess. After the pilgrim is saved once more last minute by his mighty entourage, all tree spirits are killed with prejudice. Apparently, the empty talk of poetry must be exterminated at its roots. This presentation follows the soteriological tradition and further investigates the dangers that these “thorny demons” present to the human heart.

### 4) Viewing Stones in Joseon Korea — Marc Nürnberger

Marc Nürnberger reads testimonies of Korean stone-lovers whose encounters with extraordinary stones challenge the ordinary conceptions of “materiality” and “reality,” closing the fourfold investigation into the “realms” (境) that await the connoisseur of literati works.

## Methodological Reflections

Slot 4 · 14:00–15:30 · Musiksaal (HC.K.1) · Chair: Jin Y. Park (American University)

### 1. Jinwoo Park Sungkyunkwan University

#### *Jing as a Condition of Ritual Performance*

[Abstract] Finite Rules, Infinite Situations: Jing (敬) as a Condition of Ritual Performance Park Jinwoo\* Rules are finite. Human situations are infinite. Ritual (li 禮) operates precisely within the tension between these two, yet its execution remains a challenge. This paper argues that jing (敬) names the capacity to navigate this mismatch. Contrary to the prevailing view of jing as a private attitude of reverence or respect, I argue that it is primarily an evaluative category of performance. In pre-Qin sources, jing rarely functions as a self-description; instead, it is a quality demanded by the scene and assessed by others. To illuminate this performative dimension, the paper engages with the Korean concept nunchi (눈치). Previous scholarship suggests that nunchi—the ability to read a situation—is merely a backup plan, used only to bend the rules when they fail to provide clear guidance. I contend, however, that situational awareness is not an emergency measure. In the Confucian context, it is the standing condition of every ritual act; without it, even the most precise rule-following fails to meet the demands of the moment. By reframing jing through the lens of nunchi, this paper rethinks the relationship between jing and li in early Confucian thought. Keywords: jing (敬), ritual (li 禮), nunchi

### 2. Janghee Lee Gyeongin National University of Education

#### *Asymmetry of Korean 'Philosophy' — On Metaphysics*

What is meant by “Korean philosophy”? Philosophy, or philosophy, has its origins in ancient Greek culture. The Sino-Japanese term cheolhak (哲學) was coined by Japanese scholars to translate “philosophy.” It is easy to surmise that this was because no intellectual tradition rooted in the cultural sphere of East Asia could be readily used as its equivalent. “Philosophy” was not chosen as a concept to translate terms arising from East Asian intellectual traditions such as gyeonghak (經學, the study of the Classics), jahak (子學, the study of the Masters), or dohak (道學, the Learning of the Way). Rather, the term cheolhak (“philosophy”) was created in order to translate Western



“philosophy.” From the outset, then, cheolhak stands in an asymmetrical relationship to “philosophy.” For this reason, whereas Western “philosophy” possesses a long historical substance with a clearly defined identity, Korean philosophy finds itself in a position of constantly having to gauge Western “philosophy” and being required to excavate or reconstruct its own identity in relation to it. A similar situation appears when we turn to major domains traditionally regarded as central to “philosophy,” such as metaphysics or ethics. The Korean terms hyeongisanghak (形而上學, metaphysics) and yulli-hak (倫理學, ethics) were selected as translations of “metaphysics” and “ethics”; it was not the case that metaphysics or ethics were chosen to translate preexisting East Asian concepts. In the case of yulli-hak (ethics), like cheolhak, it may be said to be a neologism coined to render “ethics.” By contrast, hyeongisang (形而上) and hak (學), both concepts with long histories in East Asian intellectual tradition, were invoked to translate the Western term “metaphysics.” Unlike cheolhak or yulli-hak, the compound hyeongisanghak—as the study of what is “above form”—can, when interpreted as the study of hyeongisang, be understood as a concept carrying significant implications within the East Asian intellectual tradition. In other words, hyeongisanghak and “metaphysics” are not merely in an asymmetrical relationship; they can each claim their own substantial standing as equivalent concepts. The question, however, is whether these two terms—each capable of asserting its own implications with equal confidence—correspond closely enough to serve adequately as translations of one another. By examining the relationship between hyeongisanghak and “metaphysics,” this presentation seeks to make more concrete the complexity of the congenital asymmetry that characterizes Korean philosophy. Through this process, we will come to witness both the promise and the predicament involved in practicing Korean philosophy.

**3. Seonhee Kim** Ewha Womans University

#### *Qi as Narrative: Understanding the Human Beyond Cognition*

Philosophy has traditionally served as a significant narrative intervening in human being and social life, across both Eastern and Western traditions. Unlike literary narrative, however, philosophy carries within it a demand for a normative and prescriptive role. If literature creates possible worlds, philosophy helps us examine and evaluate the conditions and forms of those possible worlds, together with their sustainability and expandability. Philosophy does not “create” worlds, but it provides the conditions and conceptual foundations for creation, confers intentionality upon the conditions and contexts of worlds already created, and mediates among the plurality of possible worlds. Philosophy is, moreover, always prescriptive in that it bears a responsibility toward ethical questions that are not necessarily incumbent upon literature. This study is a preliminary inquiry into whether qi (氣)—a foundational concept in East Asian thought—can be mobilized as a resource for philosophical narrative. Here, qi is proposed not as an ontological concept but as an epistemological one: a means of constructing an integrative narrative in the course of accounting for human beings and the world. Qi is not a decomposable, observable material unit or biological response of the kind denoted by terms such as energy, ether, neuron, or synapse. Rather, qi is a narrative concept designed to capture and articulate all beings and practices within a temporally provisional and spatially open field. Accordingly, qi does not strongly replicate the image of any single pole in such binaries as life/non-life, matter/mind, human/machine, or linguistic/non-linguistic, nor does it reduce to information or program. If qi is narratively constructed, can it offer an alternative discourse for accounting for human language, experience, and moral practice? This study investigates whether qi can provide a new understanding of the human being and a reinterpretation of human experience that is not confined to the traditional account of the subject and its cognitive capacities.

## **Korean Society, Feminism & Religion**

Slot 4 · 14:00–15:30 · HC.J.1.07 · Chair: Bongrae Seok (Alvernia University)

**1. Ye Eun Esther Ghim** Seoul National University

#### *Continuities in Korean New Religious Movements*

The rapid emergence and development of New Religious Movements (NRMs) in South Korea has become increasingly significant, particularly given its growing visibility on social media. However, these movements are not purely modern, but are shaped by historical suppression during colonization, psychological needs for belonging, and philosophical traditions grounded in Korea’s religious history, especially the Joseon dynasty and Eastern Learning (Cawley, 2019), which continue to inform contemporary structures of religious authority and interpretation. According to Oak (2010), the interaction between indigenous belief systems and foreign ideologies has led to the emergence of hybridised



religious expressions. This has also produced tensions, as suppressed traditions re-emerge alongside or against imposed belief systems, often resulting in competing claims to legitimacy and truth. Using Jesus Morning Star (JMS) (Arnaiz, 2024) as a case study, this presentation aims to explore how NRMs respond to and shape a crisis of cultural identity in contemporary South Korea (Creasman and Rush, 2020). Building on Cawley (2019), this presentation will explore whether leadership models from the Joseon dynasty—particularly around scriptural authority and revelation—continue to shape contemporary NRMs. Ultimately, this study argues that NRMs reflect enduring philosophical structures of belief, authority, and practice.

## **2. Jea Sophia Oh** West Chester University

### *Choe Si-hyeong's Gyeongmul and Relational Be-Coming*

This paper examines artificial intelligence through Hae-Wol Choe Si-hyeong (海月 崔時亨)'s concept of gyeongmul (敬物), one dimension of Donghak (東學)'s samgyeong (三敬: reverencing Heaven, humans, and things), employing an intersectional ecofeminist methodology. While AI is often celebrated as a hallmark of contemporary technological innovation, its design and deployment remain deeply shaped by the hierarchical logics of modernity, encoding and amplifying enduring binaries such as human over nature, subject over object, male over female, and center over margin. At the same time, a paradox emerges: although AI is constructed as an instrument of human mastery, humans increasingly find themselves governed by algorithmic systems that shape perception, decision-making, and social relations, revealing a reversal within instrumental rationality itself. Drawing on Hae-Wol's philosophy, I argue that gyeongmul offers a life-centered and relational reorientation that challenges anthropocentrism and technological domination. Without anthropomorphizing machines or attributing moral agency to them, gyeongmul destabilizes rigid ontological hierarchies and expands the ethical horizon toward reverential coexistence within an entangled web of beings. In doing so, I suggest that Donghak provides a framework for rethinking relational be-coming in ways that encompass artificial entities as part of our living environment, opening a more sustainable and ecologically attuned horizon for ethical engagement in contemporary technological life.

## **3. Ingrid Mae H. De Jesus** University of the Philippines – Diliman

### *A Genealogy of South Korean Feminist Thought*

Despite South Korea's rapid modernization, Confucianism remains in its social fabric with its continued influence in shaping gender roles, family dynamics, and notions of hierarchy and harmony. However, contemporary feminist movements have emerged challenging this form-of-life. This research argues that these efforts are not merely present-day phenomena; they continue a feminist tradition that dates back to the Joseon dynasty (1392–1910), with Im Yunjidang and Gang Jeongildang—who laid early foundations for feminist discourse by asserting women's moral-intellectual capacities despite teachings of Confucian orthodoxy. Turning to modern South Korean feminist movements—#MeToo's exposure of systemic sexual violence, Escape the Corset's rejection of oppressive beauty standards, and 4B's radical refusal of heterosexual dating, marriage, sex, and childbirth—this work sees them as philosophical resistance to Confucianism's gendered relational ethics. Connecting Joseon-era assertions to twenty-first century activism, the paper demonstrates that South Korean feminism is a continuum that has inherited traditions while generating new modes of resistance. This genealogy underscores feminism's role in reshaping philosophical discourse and lived realities in Korea, with the analysis demonstrating the possibility of critically reassessing and renegotiating women's roles, expectations, and social situatedness; thereby advancing women's emancipation even within the constraints of entrenched gendered norms.

## **Intercultural & Comparative**

Slot 4 · 14:00–15:30 · HC.J.2.09 · Chair: Sool Park (University of Hildesheim)

## **1. David Kim** University of San Francisco

### *Joseon Gyeong in Woodruff's Greco-Chinese Matrix*

In his book, *Reverence: Renewing a Forgotten Virtue*, Paul Woodruff offers an account of a universal core nature of reverence and how reverence, so understood, manifests in classical Greek and classical Chinese philosophies and cultures. My essay both introduces Joseon Confucian philosophical work on reverence/gyeong to Woodruff's

framework and uses the former as a critical vantage point for examining the latter both substantively and meta-philosophically.

This critical synthesis is relevant to the current NAKPA conference theme in two ways. First, arguably, reverence is one of the most consistently and deeply discussed emotions by Joseon Confucian scholars, which invites us to consider how their work may fare relative to Woodruff's Greek- and Chinese-sourced insights. His account is the first English-language book-length treatment of the nature and virtue of reverence, so this is an interesting opportunity to showcase some elements of Joseon philosophy. Second, his account is distinctly intercultural in the way it weaves together contemporary, classical Greek, and classical Chinese philosophical work. But it is also committed to a kind of universalist core regarding the nature of reverence. It has some structural features that resemble what some have elsewhere called a "floating signifier," and it is an under-explained element of his account. This affords us an opportunity to reflect upon how metaphilosophical commitments manifest in a substantive analysis.

## **2. Boram Jeong** University of Colorado Denver

### *A Phenomenology of Nunchi and Affective Attunement*

While the Korean concept of nunchi (눈치)—the art of attuning to social environments and gauging others' moods and unspoken intentions—is often popularized as a communal antidote to Western individualism, its philosophical dimensions remain under-theorized. This paper develops a phenomenology of nunchi by drawing on Sara Ahmed's work on affective attunement and mood. I argue that nunchi, as a heightened form of social awareness and sensitivity, constitutes a pre-reflective bodily orientation informed by the norms around social spatio-temporality. Rather than treating space-time as a formal and neutral structure of experience, nunchi-informed perception assesses the "adequacy" of social rhythm: the timing of speech, the speed of reading an atmosphere, and the duration of shared activities. Spatially, it involves a social grammar of embodiment and comportment: the propriety of one's spatial positioning relative to their social rank within a collective, the appropriate distance or proximity between bodies, the volume of space that one's body occupies. I contend that because nunchi requires identifying and conforming to these normative spatio-temporal orders, it is inherently entangled with dynamics of power. This paper concludes that the burden of habituating nunchi often falls disproportionately upon those in subordinate positions, who must maintain the affective attunement and harmony by reproducing the very dominant order that marginalizes them.

## **3. Qian Ran** Ruhr-University Bochum

### *Truth and Public Discourse*

Both truth and public sphere are often regarded as concepts that are completely foreign to Confucianism. Many authors follow the linguistic study of the sinologist Chad Hansen, deny a concept of truth for the whole Chinese philosophy, at least the one which was not impacted by Buddhistic doctrines. As for public sphere, it is equally difficult to imagine such a concept in pre-modern China, if we follow Habermas' dichotomy of the "representative public sphere" on the one hand and the "civil public sphere" on the other. Within the framework of the culture of debate in pre-modern China, I undertake a thorough explanation of the Chinese concept of gong and argue that there is a deep-seated conviction among Confucians and Confucian literati that truth and public discourse are intimately connected. In this regard, the first question that arises is how a concept of truth can be understood in pre-modern China, particularly in light of Hansen's assertion that Chinese philosophy has no concept of truth, but also with regard to various Western concepts of truth. Subsequently, I will show the relationship between truth and public discourse in the Confucian sense. Based on this relationship I will briefly review the culture of debate in pre-modern China in the last section.

## **Korean Culture & Religion**

Slot 5 · 16:00–17:30 · Musiksaal (HC.K.1) · Chair: Youngsun Back (Sungkyunkwan University)

## **1. Anthony Curtis Adler** Yonsei University

### *A Tale of Two Dragons: Bong Joon Ho and Daoist Nature*

The following paper will explore how the celebrated Korean director Bong Joon Ho engages with Daoist concepts of "nature," arguing that a Daoist-inflected view of nature as atelic, spontaneously self-creating, and errant in its movements is not only a constant theme throughout his oeuvre, but indeed stands in an intimate relation to his own

conception of cinema as an expressive medium. A special focus will be the movie *Snowpiercer*, which challenges the "Western" appropriation of Eastern philosophical ideas of the harmonious ordering of nature while holding out the possibility of a more authentic encounter with nature in its spontaneous becoming. In *Snowpiercer*, the train represents a technical ordering of nature according to an appropriated principle of harmony and balance. While the final destruction of the trains threatens humanity with extinction, it also allows nature to present itself outside of its capture within the technological apparatus of the train.

## **2. HyeonMinh Ryu** Seoul National University

### *Xunzi's Sanhuo and the Limits of Counter-Naming*

**Xunzi's Sanhuo and the Limits of Counter-Naming** This paper argues that non-Western philosophical resources, read symptomatically, can formalize mechanisms Western stigma theory leaves implicit. Goffman and Link & Phelan show stigma entails status loss, discrimination, and foreclosed life chances, and resistance cannot overcome power differentials — but do not explain how counter-naming generates additional stigmatization. Through a symptomatic reading of Xunzi's sanhuo(三惑) taxonomy, this paper argues stigma is a structural trap: escape attempts through counter-naming deepen rather than dissolve it. Xunzi grounds naming in politically-established convention (mingque, 名約). The sanhuo taxonomy classifies challenges on two criteria: the factual (same/different, 同異) and the normative (precious/base, 貴賤). Counter-naming importing a different value judgment is classifiable as yiming luanming (以名亂名) on normative grounds; if polysemous, also as yiming luanshi (以名亂實) on factual grounds. Both axes are independent and deployable simultaneously. Whichever dimension is foregrounded, the other generates fresh grounds for rejection — multiplying consequences each time. Heresy discourse in Korean Protestantism serves as an empirical case. Heresy Deliberation Committees hold authority over mingque, designating groups as idan (heresy). When groups designated idan claim jeongtong (orthodox), this imports a different judgment of legitimacy, classifiable as yiming luanming; polysemous doctrinal claims invite dismissal as yiming luanshi. The result is, paradoxically, compounded stigmatization. This is why stigma is indelible.

## **3. Wonjean Lee** Sookmyung Women's University

### *Hauntology and Techno-shamanism in Korean Specter Narratives*

This paper explores the "Hauntology(Derrida)" of contemporary Korean culture—from Han Kang's literature and Chung Bora's *Cursed Bunny* to the drama *The Devil*—as a way to face the "remote action" of historical hate. While modern hate functions as a blind exclusion that ignores our ontological entanglements, I argue that true historical responsibility requires a deliberate "Agential Cut" (Karen Barad)—a practical decision to recognize and respond to specific specters within the vast web of the past. Drawing on Barad's Agential Realism and Shan Kan's work on Techno-shamanism, I propose to mend the disjointed joints of time through the lens of Che-yong(體用, Essence and Function). In this framework, the Shaman acts as the Essence—the one who listens to the pain of specters—while Technology serves as the Function—the digital tool that facilitates this ethical encounter. An example is found in Ken Liu's sci-fi, where a "chrono-imaging" machine allows for an active cut that captures the voices of 731 Unit victims, transforming the "remote action" of past pain into a sacred response-ability. Through the project, I demonstrate how this "Techno-shamanic" intervention provides a site for ethical re-mapping. By using technological mediation to perform a purposeful "cut" into the silence of history, we can heal the wounds of hate.

## **Modern Korean Thought & Intercultural**

Slot 5 · 16:00–17:30 · HC.J.1.07 · Chair: Bongrae Seok (Alvernia University)

## **1. Song Chong Lee** Seoul National University

### *Ham Sok Hon's Reception of Henri Bergson*

This paper examines Ham Sok Hon's (1901–1989) engagement with Henri Bergson's philosophy of life as a neglected but illuminating dimension of his nonviolent thought. I argue that Bergson's three interlocking concepts, élan vital, duration (la durée), and intuition, offer a productive philosophical lens through which Ham's own ssial (seed/the masses) philosophy can be read in explicitly cosmological and moral terms. It must be noted at the outset that Ham's references to Bergson are sporadic and unsystematic, never developed into sustained philosophical commentary. The parallels explored in this paper are therefore the product of my own constructive interpretation, a close reading that

traces shared conceptual concerns rather than direct intellectual lineage. Where Bergson mapped the expansiveness of life onto biological and metaphysical terrain, Ham transposed analogous intuitions onto history, ethics, and the possibilities of civilizational transformation. This will further situate the conversation within the Korean scholarly debate over whether Ham's philosophy of history constitutes a form of social Darwinism, arguing that a Bergsonian reading reframes that binary by revealing a third position, one grounded in spiritual evolutionism and nonviolent moral imagination.

## 2. Sunuk Kim University of Hildesheim

### *Seiendes, 存在者, and the Limits of Ontological Difference*

Seiendes, 存在者, and the Limits of Ontological Difference It is well known that when Heidegger's works were translated in East Asia, a new conceptual articulation was required to render his notion of ontological difference. In Korea, China, and Japan, the German terms Sein and Seiendes were translated as 存在 and 存在者. Yet a fundamental question remains: what is the semantic function of the character 者 in 存在者? Although in modern Korean usage 者 often refers to a person, its earlier classical usage did not signify an individual subject. Rather, 者 functions to indicate a situational configuration or a state of affairs. Through close readings of passages from the Zhuangzi and the Mencius, the semantic and textual origins of 者 are examined. It is argued that 者 originally functioned as a marker that designates a situational configuration. Only secondarily did it acquire a predominantly nominalizing role. This analysis demonstrates that the formation of -者 in East Asian languages does not operate analogously to German participial formation. The absence of a direct linguistic equivalent to Heidegger's ontological difference, therefore, should not be interpreted as a conceptual absence in East Asian philosophical traditions. Rather, it leads to a reconsideration of ontological difference itself, which understands Being as situational designation rather than as nominalization. On this basis, the paper proposes a reconsideration of ontological difference that approaches Being as event. (230 words)

## 3. Yookyung Nho-von Blumröder University of Cologne

### *Music as Comparative Philosophy: Korean Thought Becoming Audible Form*

This paper proposes that music can do comparative philosophy — not illustrate it, not accompany it, but enact it. Where comparative philosophy is conventionally understood as a textual operation that places traditions side by side for analysis, this paper argues that musical composition can constitute a properly philosophical act in which incommensurable traditions become mutually audible within a single temporal structure.

The compositional oeuvre of Younghi Pagh-Paan (b. 1945) is read as a sustained case for this claim. From the early Dreisam-Nore, in which the Daoist 上善若水 and the Heraclitean panta rhei unfold as one flowing temporality, through works engaging Buddhist emptiness (空) and Confucian relational thought, to later compositions such as In luce ambulemus (2007/2012) — where Laozi's 損之又損, Meister Eckhart's humilitas ab humo, the Pauline kenosis (Phil 2:7), and the Korean cosmological triad 天地人 cohere within a single sonic form — Pagh-Paan's work performs comparative thought as time rather than describing it.

Drawing on the analytical framework developed in Das transparente Licht (Wolke 2021) — SSUM, Gin-SSUM, Wandeln, Durchsichtigkeit, durchbrochene Arbeit, and the method of Reduktion (음악적 비움) — the paper shows how apophatic resources from Daoist, Buddhist, and Christian traditions converge across Pagh-Paan's work not through synthesis but through the audible time of an emptied form. Korean philosophy, here, is neither object of comparison nor exported subject; it thinks, in sound.

## Comparative Confucian Ethics

Slot 5 · 16:00–17:30 · HC.J.2.09 · Chair: Hwa Yeong Wang (Duke Kunshan University)

### 1. George Tsai University of Hawai'i

#### *Generative AI and the Loss of Practice: A Confucian Account*

Recent discussions of generative AI have focused on familiar concerns such as bias, labor displacement, and responsibility. This paper considers a different question: what is lost when technologies reproduce the products of human activities while bypassing participation in the practices that sustain them? It develops a Confucian, practice-

centered account of value on which many forms of value arise through participation in socially structured activities that cultivate evaluative capacities.

Early Confucian philosophy offers a particularly clear articulation of this idea through its account of ritual (li), especially in the works of Confucius, Mencius, and Xunzi. Ritual participation is treated not merely as expressive behavior but as a formative activity that shapes perception, emotion, and judgment. Through engagement in ritual, agents acquire the capacities required to recognize and respond appropriately to ethical situations. On this view, value is not located solely in outcomes but emerges through cultivated forms of responsiveness grounded in practice.

This perspective bears on the ethical assessment of generative AI. Technologies that bypass participation in practices may weaken the conditions under which the relevant capacities are formed. The paper argues that evaluating such technologies requires attention not only to their products but also to their effects on the practices through which human values become intelligible.

## **2. Lok Chui Choo** University of Hawai'i

### *Resentment (Yuan) and Dasan's Moral Psychology*

This paper examines Jeong Yagyong's (Dasan, 1762–1836) account of yuan (怨) as a distinctive form of emotional response to suffering, and argues that it can be understood as a form of tragic resentment. While recent work in contemporary moral philosophy has explored non-moral resentment, these accounts remain largely confined to interpersonal contexts. By contrast, Dasan's moral psychology allows us to extend such responses beyond interpersonal relations to the human relationship with Heaven (天).

Dasan understands emotions as integral to ethical life and grounded in the normative order established by Heaven. Rejecting the metaphysical abstraction of orthodox Neo-Confucianism, he emphasizes concrete human feelings and sympathetic understanding as the basis of moral judgment. Within this framework, yuan, especially when directed toward Heaven, is not a response to moral wrongdoing but to the experience of suffering in a world that does not align with human expectations.

I argue that such yuan constitutes a form of tragic resentment: an intelligible and ethically significant response that expresses the agent's sense of loss, frustration, or misrecognition without attributing blame. This interpretation highlights how Dasan's philosophy broadens the scope of reactive emotions, showing that emotionally charged responses to Heaven and the world can remain meaningful within a Confucian ethical framework.

### *3. To be announced*